



APPS



Discord's virtual reward,
'Orbs,' launches out of
beta

After [announcing](#) in late May that the platform would be experimenting with a new virtual reward system, Discord is now launching it to the public. The aim of the rewards, called Orbs, is to get people to click on more interactive ads.

Users earn Orbs after completing Quests, which involve interacting with ads for products or games to get virtual items. Users can redeem Orbs for digital items in Discord's Shop, like a three-day Nitro credit, an Orb-themed profile badge, profile effects, avatar decorations, and more.

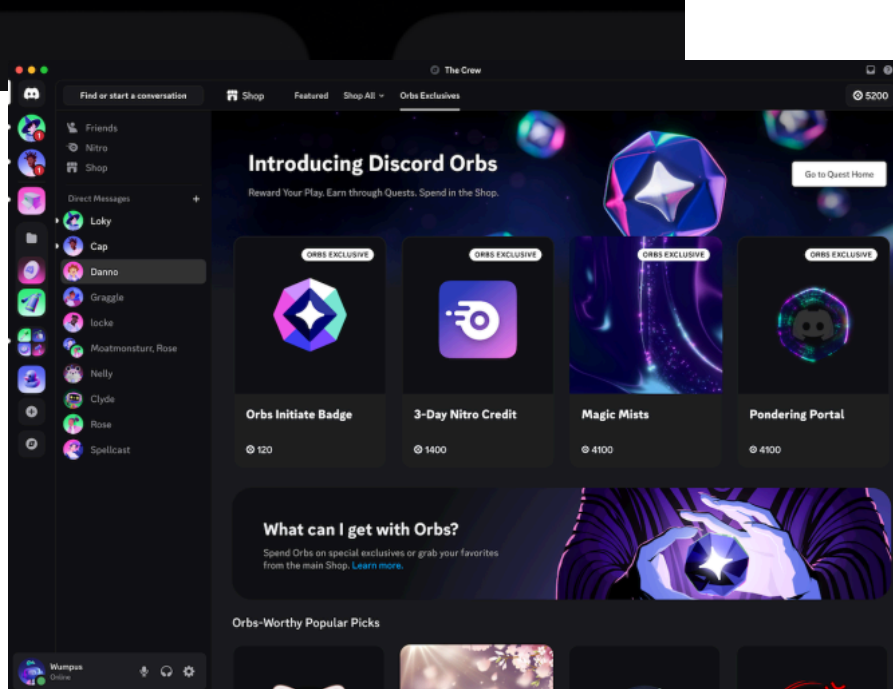


IMAGE CREDITS:DISCORD

According to Discord, Orbs have been popular among testers, with millions earned and spent during the seven-week beta period. Other company data shows that there was a 16-fold increase in

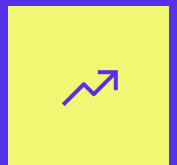
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first-time purchases in the Shop, with 79% of participants having never bought anything before.

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Discord is said to be [considering an IPO](#) and is looking to show potential partners that it can maintain a scalable ad model. Discord is marketing Orbs to advertisers as a simpler way to launch Quest campaigns without needing to create their own rewards.

The Orbs experiment is also likely meant to attract users who do not have a subscription to try Nitro, as they can use Orbs to purchase credits. However, it's unclear whether there was an increase in subscriptions. The company didn't respond to a request for comment, but it did mention that 70% of Orbs participants were nonmembers.

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Lauren Forristal

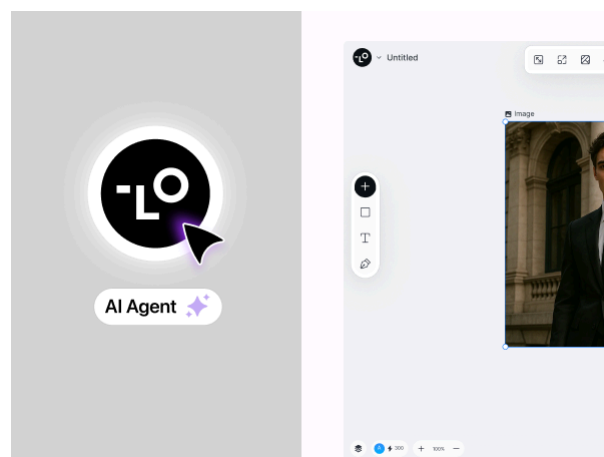


Lauren covers media, streaming, apps and platforms at TechCrunch.

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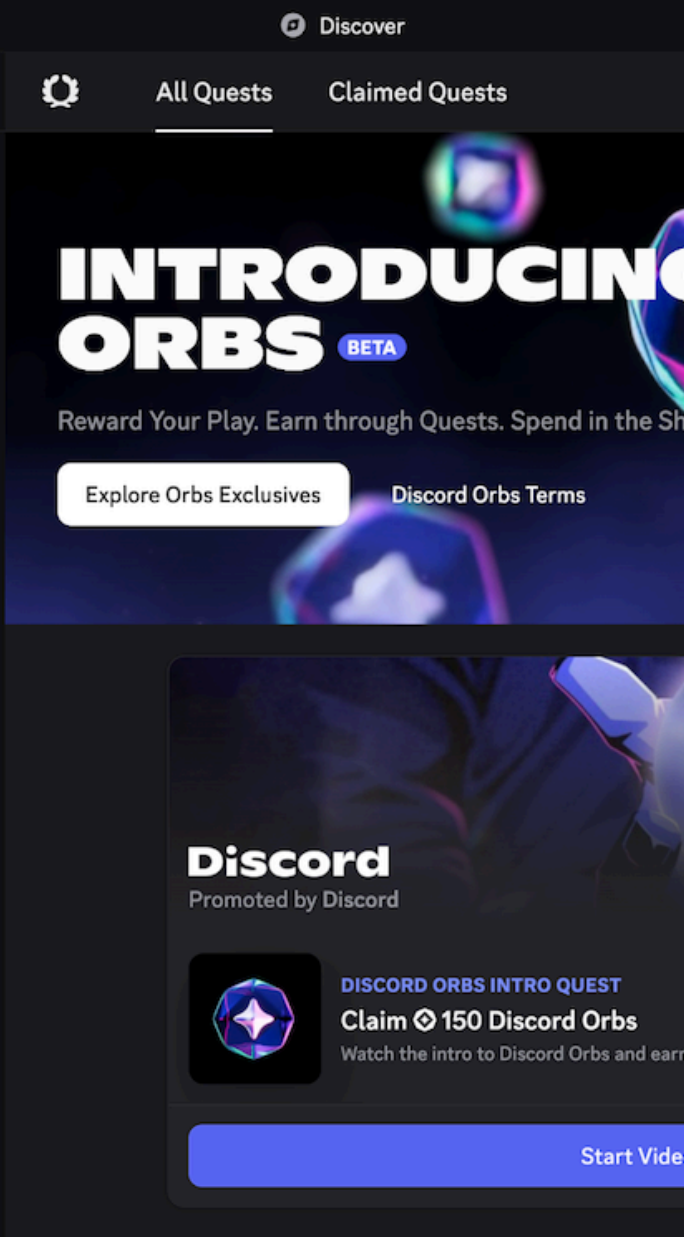


IMAGE CREDITS: DISCORD

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Discord explores virtual rewards for its ad product as it prepares for a potential IPO

Lauren Forristal — 7:57 AM PDT · May 28, 2025

Discord [announced](#) on Wednesday that it's experimenting with a new virtual reward system aimed at encouraging more users to engage with its interactive ads. This new feature, called "[Orbs](#)," comes on the heels of the company preparing for a [potential IPO](#).

Users can earn Orbs by completing "[Quests](#)," Discord's ad format where advertisers incentivize users to watch product videos or play games by rewarding them with virtual items. The addition of Orbs gives users the chance to redeem exclusive digital items from Discord's Shop, including Nitro

Advertisement

credits, profile badges, avatar decorations, profile effects, and items from main collections.

It’s clear that the goal of Orbs is to encourage more interaction with Quests as Discord seeks to demonstrate to partners that it can offer a scalable ad business. The company has reportedly discussed a possible IPO with investment bankers, per [The New York Times](#).

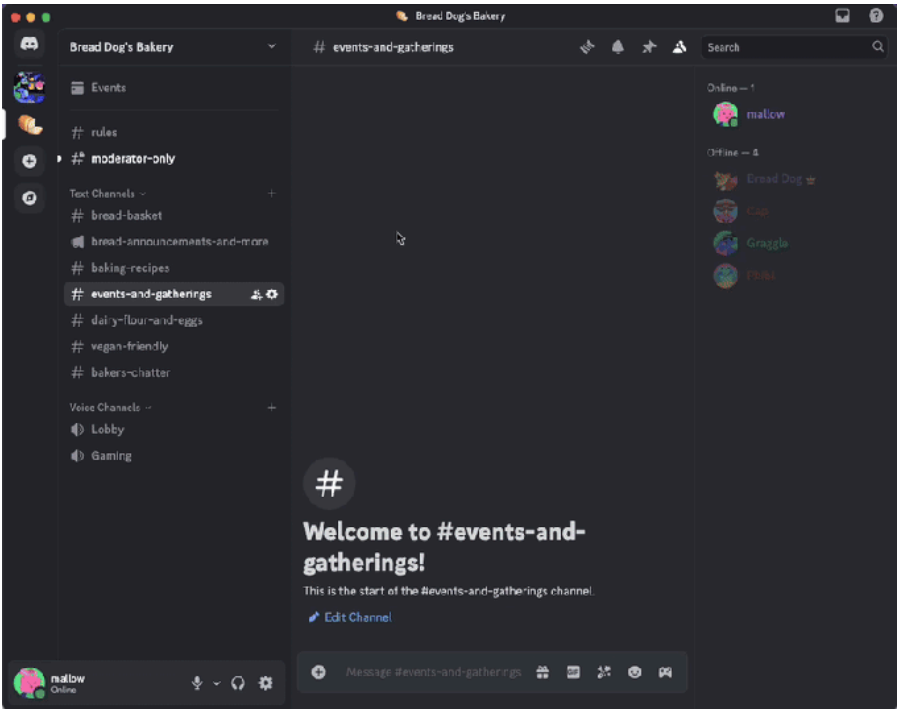


IMAGE CREDITS:DISCORD

Last month, [Peter Sellis](#), Discord’s senior vice president of product, highlighted the success of Quests. He reported that, over the past year, more than 70 Quests achieved a 10% acceptance rate with millions of rewards earned, according to the company’s internal data.

Quests are located in the bottom left corner of the app on PC. Plans are in place to [expand Quests to mobile devices](#) in June.

The Orbs experiment may also entice users who don’t have a subscription to try Nitro, as they can spend Orbs on credits instead of using a payment method. For instance, users need 1,400 Orbs to get three free days of Nitro, which typically costs \$10 per month.

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Orbs is being rolled out to a small group of users and will soon expand globally.



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This story was updated to clarify that Quests are not available on gaming consoles.

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Lauren Forristal



Lauren covers media, streaming, apps and platforms at TechCrunch.

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Increased oversight: Discord tests new parental controls for teens

Sarah Perez — 11:11 AM PDT · May 22, 2023

IMAGE CREDITS:

MARTIN BUREAU/AFP VIA GETTY IMAGES

New usernames aren't the only change coming to the popular chat app Discord, now used by 150

[million](#) people every month. The company is also testing a suite of parental controls that would allow for increased oversight of Discord's youngest users, TechCrunch has learned and Discord confirmed. In a live test running in Discord's iOS app in the U.S., the company introduced a new "Family Center" feature, where parents will be able to configure tools that allow them to see the names and avatars of their teen's recently added friends, the servers the teen has joined or participated in and the names and avatars of users they've directly messaged or engaged with in group chats.

However, Discord clarifies in an informational screen, parents will not be able to view the content of their teen's messages or calls in order to respect their privacy.

This approach, which toes a fine line between the need for parental oversight and a minor's right to privacy, is similar to how [Snapchat implemented parental controls](#) in its app last year. Like Discord's system, Snapchat only allows parents insights into who their teen is talking to and friending, not what they've typed or the media they've shared.

Users who are part of the Discord test will see the new Family Center hub linked under the app's User Settings section, below the Privacy & Safety and Profiles sections. From here, parents are able to read an overview of the Family Center features and click a button to "Get Started" when they're ready to set things up.

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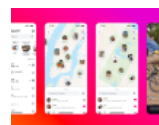
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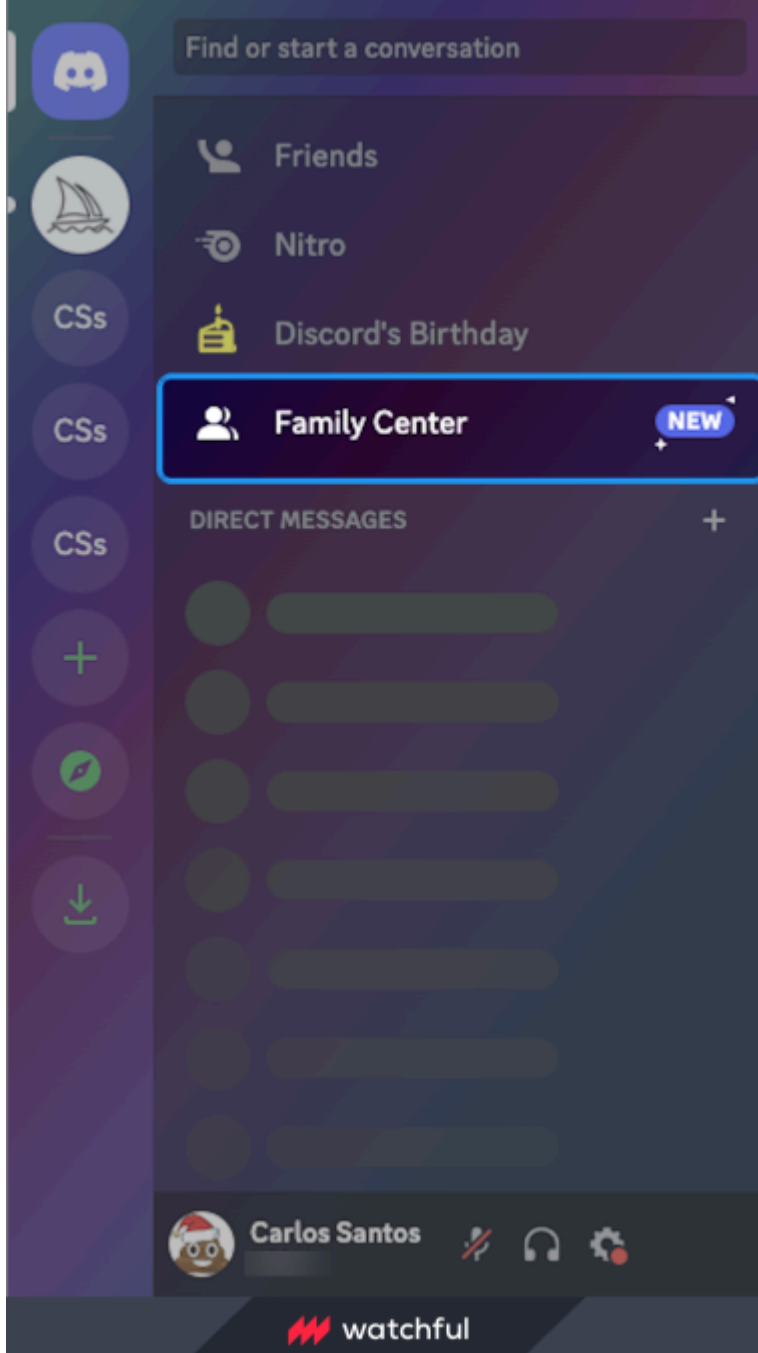


IMAGE CREDITS: DISCORD SCREENSHOT VIA WATCHFUL.AI

Discord explains on this screen that it “built Family Center to provide you with more content on how your teen uses Discord so you can work together on building positive online behaviors.” It then details the various parental controls, which will allow them to see who their teen is chatting with and friending, and which servers they join and participate in.

Similar to TikTok, parents can scan a QR code provided by the teen to put the account under their supervision.

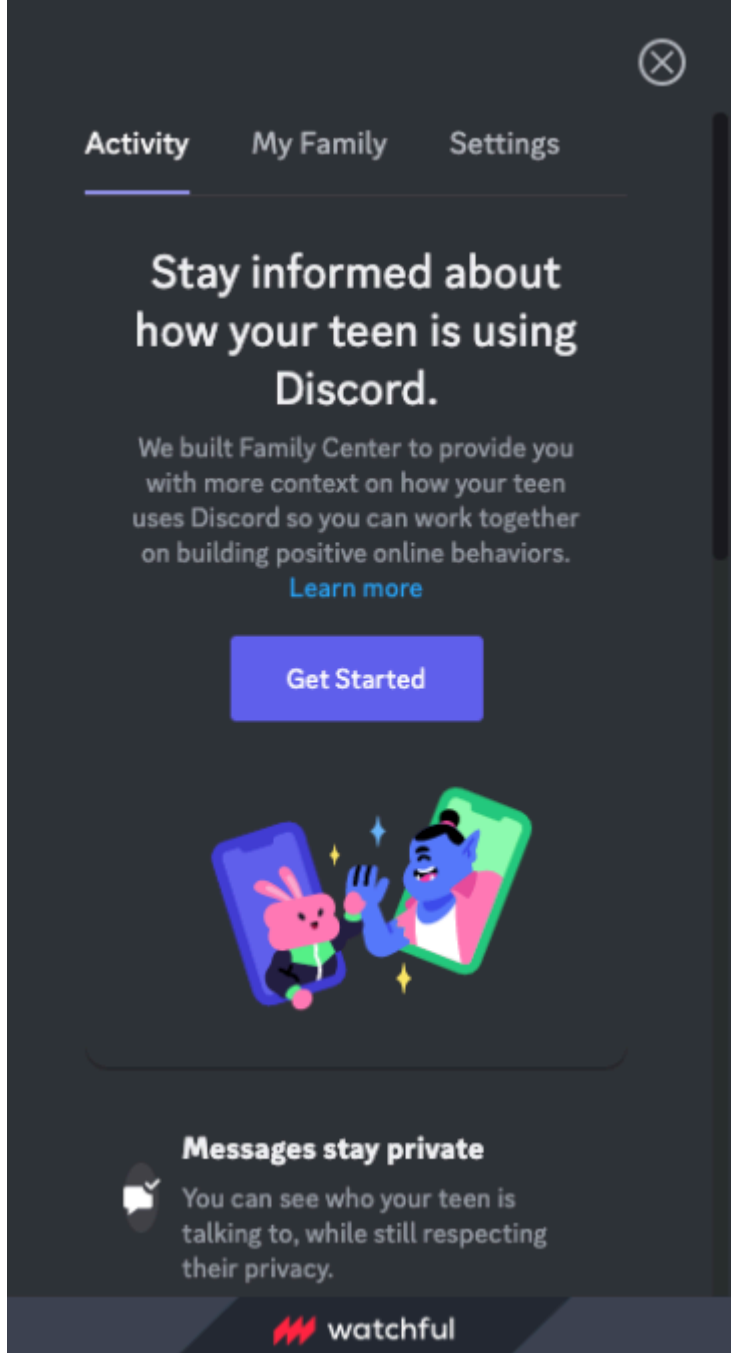


IMAGE CREDITS:

DISCORD SCREENSHOT VIA WATCHFUL.AI

The screenshots were discovered by app intelligence firm [Watchful.ai](#). In addition, a handful of users [had posted their own screenshots](#) on Twitter when they encountered the new experience earlier this year, or had simply [remarked](#) on the feature when coming across it in the app.

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We reached Discord for comment on the tests, showing them some screenshots from the test. The company confirmed the development but didn't offer a firm commitment as to when or if the parent control feature would actually roll out.

"We're always working to improve our platform and keep users safe, particularly our younger users," a Discord spokesperson said. "We'll let you know if and when something comes of this work," they added.

The company declined to answer our questions about the reach of the tests, or whether it planned to offer the tools outside the U.S., among other things.

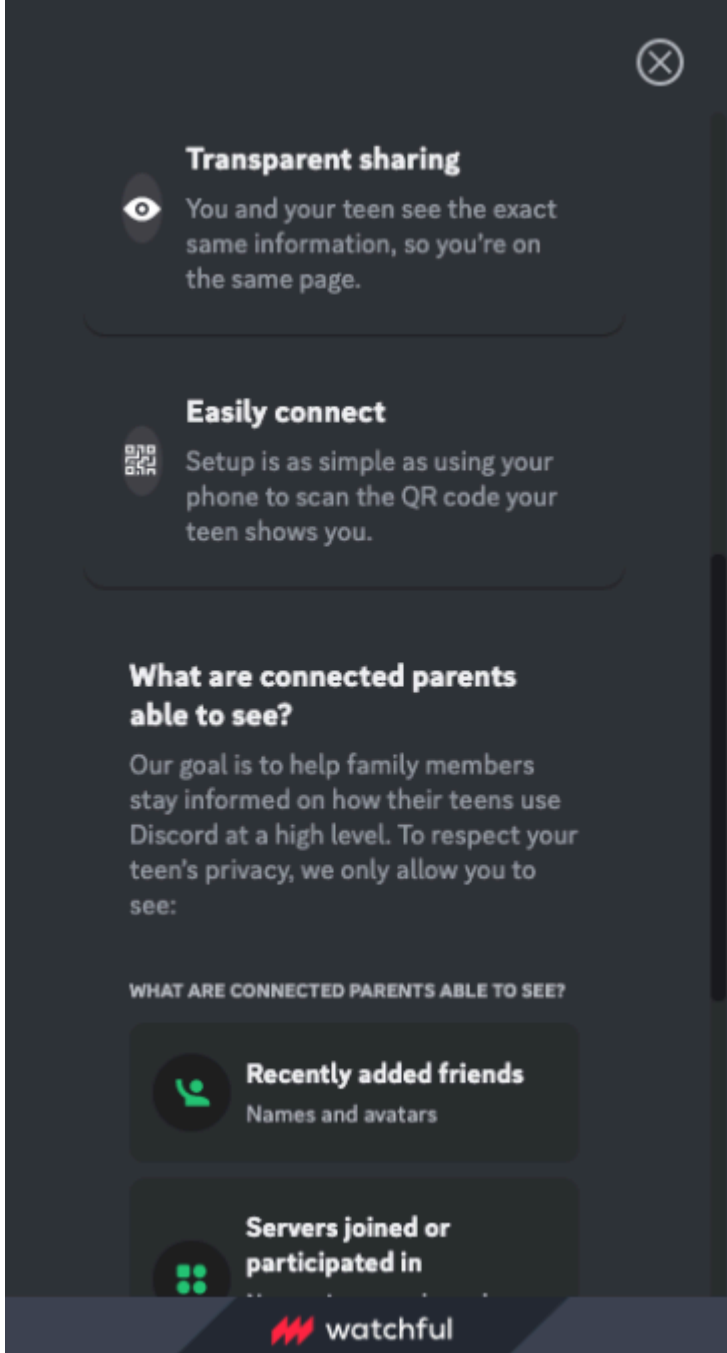


IMAGE CREDITS:

DISCORD SCREENSHOT VIA WATCHFUL.AI

Though Discord today is regularly used by a younger, Gen Z crowd, thanks to its roots in being a home for gamers, it's often left out of the larger conversation around the harms to teens caused by social media use. Meanwhile, as execs from [Facebook](#), [Twitter](#), [Instagram](#), [Snap](#), [YouTube](#) and [TikTok](#) have had to testify before Congress on this topic, Discord has been able to sit on the sidelines.

Hoping to get ahead of expected regulations, most major social media companies have since rolled out parental control features for their apps, if they didn't already offer such tools. [YouTube](#) and

[Instagram](#) announced plans for parental controls in 2021, and Instagram finally [launched](#) them in 2022 with other Meta apps to follow. [Snapchat](#) also rolled out parental controls in 2022. And TikTok, which already had parental controls before the congressional inquiries began, has been [beefing them up in recent months](#).

But with the lack of regulation at the federal level, several U.S. states have begun their own laws around social media use, including new restrictions on social media apps in states like [Utah](#) and [Montana](#), as well as broader legislation to protect minors, like [California's Age Appropriate Design Code Act](#), which goes into [effect](#) next year.

Discord, so far, has flown under the radar, despite the warnings from [child safety experts](#), [law enforcement](#) and the [media](#) about the dangers the app poses to minors, [amid reports](#) that [groomers](#) and [sexual predators](#) have been [using the service](#) to target children. The nonprofit organization, the National Center on Sexual Exploitation, even [added Discord](#) to its “Dirty Dozen List” over its failures to “adequately address the sexually exploitative content and activity on its platform,” it says.

The organization specifically calls out Discord's lack of meaningful age verification technology, insufficient moderation, and inadequate safety settings.

Today, Discord offers its users access to [an online safety center](#) that guides users and parents on how to manage a safe Discord account or server, but it doesn't go so far as to actually provide parents with tools to monitor their child's use of the service or block them from joining servers or communicating with unknown persons. The new parental controls won't address the latter two concerns, however, but they are at least an acknowledgment that some sort of parental controls are needed.

This is a shift from Discord's earlier position on the matter, as the company [told The Wall Street Journal in early 2021](#) its philosophy was to put users first, not their parents, and said it wasn't planning on adding such a feature.

Topics: [Apps](#) [discord](#) [parental controls](#) [privacy](#)

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Sarah Perez

Consumer News Editor | [X](#) [Twitter](#) [@](#) [in](#)

Sarah has worked as a reporter for TechCrunch since August 2011. She joined the company after having...

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SOCIAL



Discord expands its plans to sell custom avatars and other virtual items

What's your look?

Express your vibe, buy
your profile for



After introducing an in-app shop that invited premium subscribers to buy digital decorations for their profiles, Discord now wants everybody to get in on the goods.

Discord is expanding access to its virtual shop, first launched in October, allowing users who don't pay for a monthly Nitro subscription to purchase cosmetic updates to make their profiles and avatars stand out. Nitro members will now get a discount on the virtual items, but anyone can purchase them starting today.

The shop, available to all Discord users through the profile settings page, offers two kinds of digital decorations: avatar decorations that drape fantasy, anime or other themed customizations over your profile picture or profile effects, which add flashy animations like fluttering cherry blossoms or dramatic shattering glass to a profile page. Once purchased, you can collect decorations and cycle in whichever ones suit your mood (right now, that might be Discord's new seasonal "winter wonderland" collection).

As companies like Fortnite-maker Epic Games have demonstrated — Epic sold \$50 million worth of a single set of its in-game skins alone — custom avatars can be extremely lucrative in virtual social spaces.

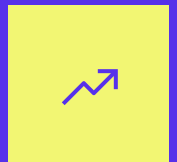
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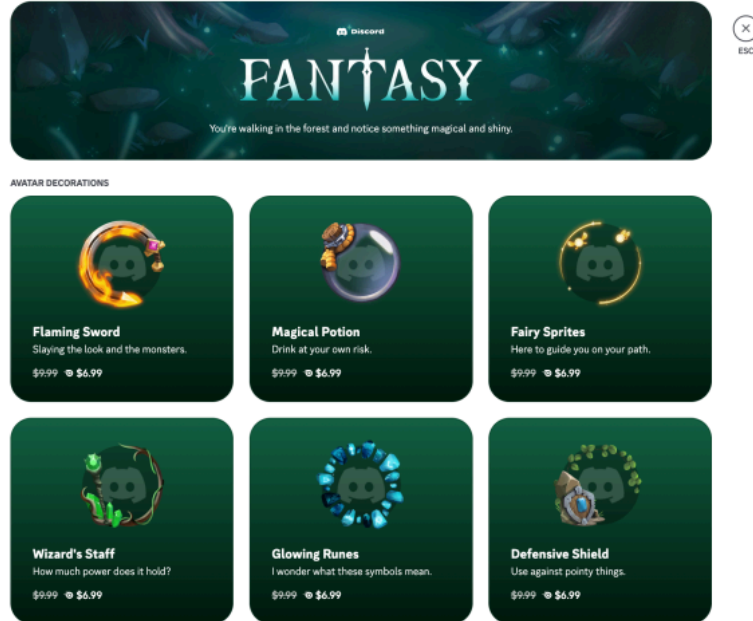


IMAGE CREDITS: DISCORD

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Users might roll their eyes at yet another social platform looking to cash in on purely decorative digital goods, but the items are another sign that Discord has little interest in unleashing a torrent of advertising onto its chat app. While more traditional social media apps like Instagram, YouTube and X (formerly Twitter) rely on aggressive in-feed advertising, Discord has eschewed the ads path over the years.

Instead the company has opted to make its premium subscription tier known as Nitro as attractive as possible to users by offering a blend of fun customizations and functional perks that appeal to casual and power users alike. Through Nitro, which comes in two tiers (\$2.99 or \$9.99 a month), Discord users can pay to enable fluffy features like custom emojis or pay more to turn on larger upload sizes and HD video streaming — vital tools for anyone who relies on Discord for community-building or any kind of business.

The avatar decorations and animations are all crafted by Discord itself for now, but the company has signaled its interest in helping its community monetize on the platform, like letting server owners put their own digital goods up for sale. For now, Discord's shop will open up a new revenue stream

for Discord itself, but to its credit, the company generally likes to bring its community along for the ride too — something to keep an eye on in the future.



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Discord is growing its developer monetization efforts



In a time when X (formerly Twitter) and Reddit have sequestered API access behind steep paywalls, Discord is taking the opposite approach.

A few weeks ago, Discord enabled U.S. developers to sell their apps to Discord users in a centralized hub, and today, that feature expands to include developers in the U.K. and Europe. Developers ... [Continue reading](#)

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